Before You Build

Finding Where You're Needed in Your Community's Hunger Landscape

A Course for Community Members Ready to Act

Course Design Document

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For reviewers: This is a course design document for a community-based program I conceived of and designed. **Module 4 is developed to full design depth**, with activities specified through objectives and instructions. Design notes at the end describe assessment philosophy, accessibility, and key design decisions.

Course Description

You know something needs to be done about hunger in your community. Maybe you've been volunteering at a food pantry and can see the lines getting longer or your neighborhood lost its only grocery store. Maybe you're part of a group that's ready to act but isn't sure where to start.

Before You Build is a five-session guided exploration for individuals and teams who want to strategically address food insecurity in communities. Rather than jumping straight to solutions, this course teaches how to read the community's hunger landscape to understand what already exists, what's changing, and where the real gaps are, so you can direct your energy where it will matter most.

You move from self-assessment through community mapping and systems analysis to produce a Strategic Focus Brief: a document that identifies a specific, evidence-based area of need and articulates why you are positioned to address it. This deliverable mirrors real-world nonprofit planning and can serve as a foundation for grant applications, board presentations, or coalition-building conversations.

The course is designed for independent learners or small teams working together. No nonprofit experience is required, just the willingness to look carefully before you leap.

One thing to know before you start: People in your community are already working on hunger and food insecurity. This course is designed to enhance your conversations with them, not replace your expertise. Each session includes a live discussion — with your team or with a peer — and participants are encouraged to invite a practitioner such as a pantry coordinator, a community health worker, or a SNAP outreach specialist, to react to what you are learning, share what you've seen, and help keep the work grounded in what the community needs. The assessment tools, mapping exercises, and analysis frameworks in this course produce better outcomes when you're shaped by people with lived experience in the work.

Duration	5 sessions, 2–3 hours per session, self-paced
Audience	Community members, emerging organizers, faith groups, civic teams, or anyone motivated to address local food insecurity
Format	Asynchronous online; works for individuals or cohort groups
Final Deliverable	Strategic Focus Brief identifying a community hunger gap and recommending a direction for action
Prerequisites	None

Course-Level Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, learners will be able to:

1. Identify your personal and team strengths, individual preferences, available resources, and realistic commitment levels for community hunger work.

2. Map existing hunger-related services, programs, and networks within your community, including government, nonprofit, and informal efforts.
3. Consider changing economic, demographic, policy, and environmental conditions that affect food access in your area.
4. Identify specific gaps or underserved populations in your community's food security landscape using evidence gathered through the course.
5. Evaluate potential areas of focus based on community need, existing coverage, and your team's capacity and positioning.
6. Produce a Strategic Focus Brief that synthesizes findings into an actionable recommendation for where to direct effort.

Course Structure

MODULE 1 Session 1	**Starting With You** Self-assessment of motivations, assumptions, capacity, and team strengths.
MODULE 2 Session 2	**Mapping What Exists** Researching and documenting the current hunger-response ecosystem in your community.
MODULE 3 Session 3	**Reading What's Changing** Analyzing emerging factors that are shifting your community's food access landscape.
MODULE 4 Session 4 *Includes outlined learning activities.*	**Finding the Gap** Synthesizing research into gap identification and strategic decision-making.
MODULE 5 Session 5	**From Findings to Focus** Building the Strategic Focus Brief and planning next steps.

Module 1: Starting With You

Session 1 | 2–3 hours

This module grounds you in honest self-assessment before you look outward. It surfaces assumptions about hunger that could bias your research, establishes a realistic picture of what you and your team can commit to, and begins the relationship with practitioners already doing food insecurity work in the community. Before interpreting your own strengths, you connect with someone whose experience will shape how you read your assessment results.

Module Objectives:

- Identify personal motivations, assumptions, and potential biases about food insecurity in your community.
- Assess individual and team capacity including time, skills, connections, and resources.
- Articulate a commitment framework that accounts for different energy and availability levels.

Activities:

- **Assumptions Inventory:** With guided reflection, surface what you think you know about hunger in your area, then flag which assumptions are based on evidence and which on perception.
- **Capacity Compass:** Use the results from the self-assessment tool to further map your time, skills, connections, and resources. Team version allows members to see collective strengths and gaps.
- **Commitment Tiers:** Define your core commitment (always), capacity commitment (when able), and stretch commitment (when conditions allow), establishing sustainable engagement from the start.
- **Practitioner Connection:** Before completing the self-assessment, identify and reach out to at least one person already working on food insecurity in your community. The goal is a brief conversation:
    - What does this work look like on the ground?
    - What roles matter most?
    - What do new groups get wrong?

  This conversation provides context that shapes how you interpret your capability assessment results and informs every subsequent module. The practitioner is invited to join a session discussion, and you are encouraged to invite different practitioners throughout the course to bring a range of perspectives from the field.
- **Module Deliverable:** Personal or team capacity profile and assumptions log for later comparison against findings.

Module 2: Mapping What Exists

Session 2 | 2–3 hours

This session shifts your focus outward to document what's already happening in your community's hunger-response ecosystem. This module prevents duplication of effort and builds the evidence base for later analysis.

Module Objectives:

- Identify and categorize existing hunger-related services including government programs (SNAP, WIC, school meals), nonprofit organizations, faith-based efforts, and informal mutual aid.
- Document service details including populations served, geographic coverage, hours, eligibility requirements, and capacity.
- Create a visual community resource map that reveals patterns of concentration and absence.

Activities:

- **Resource Scavenger Hunt:** Structured research exercise using United Way 211 databases, government program locators, community directories, and direct outreach to build a complete service inventory.
- **Community Map:** Plot services geographically (digital or physical map) and annotate with service type, capacity, and access notes.
- **Informational Interview:** Conduct one conversation with a person working in local food assistance to learn what's working, what's strained, and what you wish existed.
- **Module Deliverable:** Annotated community resource map and service inventory.

Module 3: Reading What's Changing

Session 3 | 2–3 hours

A static map isn't enough. This module teaches you to read the forces that are actively reshaping your community's food access landscape, so you can anticipate where needs are headed, not just where you are now.

Module Objectives:

- Identify economic, demographic, environmental, and policy shifts that affect food access in your community.
- Analyze how emerging changes interact with existing services to create new vulnerabilities or opportunities.
- Distinguish between short-term disruptions and structural trends.

Activities:

- **Emerging Factors Scan:** Guided research into local data sources, census data, school free-lunch rates, grocery store openings/closings, housing cost trends, employer changes, to identify what's shifting.
- **Downstream Effects Analysis:** For each major change identified, you trace its downstream effects on food access. A factory closure doesn't just mean lost income; it

may mean lost tax revenue, reduced grocery store viability, and increased demand on food banks simultaneously.

- **Voices from the Ground:** Gather at least two perspectives from community members experiencing food insecurity, through conversation, published accounts, or community forum observation, to complement data with lived experience.
- **Module Deliverable:** Emerging factors brief documenting 3–5 significant changes and your projected impact on community food access.

Module 4: Finding the Gap

Module Overview

This is the pivot point of the course. You have spent three sessions gathering information, about yourself, about what exists in your community, and about what's changing. Now you synthesize. Module 4 teaches you to look across your data, identify where services fall short of need, and make a strategic judgment about where your effort belongs.

The module culminates in a branching scenario that simulates the kind of decision a real community team faces: your research points in more than one direction, and you need to choose a focus based on evidence, capacity, and values.

Module Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, you will be able to:

- Compare existing services against identified community needs to locate gaps in coverage, access, or quality.
- Distinguish between gaps that represent missing services and gaps that represent barriers to existing services.
- Apply a decision framework that weighs community need, existing coverage, team capacity, and feasibility.
- Articulate a strategic rationale for a chosen area of focus, supported by evidence from prior modules.

Activity 4.1: The Gap Analysis Matrix

Format: Interactive worksheet | **Time:** 45 minutes

Compile your findings from Modules 2 and 3 into a structured Gap Analysis Matrix. Using data from your community map and your emerging-factors analysis, plot existing services against identified needs across key dimensions.

Service or Program	Geographic coverage	Population served	Type of food assistance	Hours and accessibility	Cultural responsiveness

The matrix makes visible what's missing. Identify at least three gaps, places where community need is not adequately met by current resources.

Deliverable: Completed Gap Analysis Matrix with three or more identified gaps, each supported by at least two data points from previous module work.

Activity 4.2: Service Gap vs. Access Barrier

Format: eLearning interaction (drag-and-drop sorting) | **Time:** 20 minutes

Not every gap means a missing program. Sometimes the service exists but people can't reach it because of transportation, language, stigma, hours of operation, documentation requirements, or lack of awareness. This activity teaches you to distinguish between two fundamentally different types of gaps, because each calls for a different response.

You will sort 10 community scenarios into "Service Gap" (no program addresses this need) or "Access Barrier" (a program exists but something prevents people from using it). After sorting, you receive feedback explaining the distinction for each scenario and why it matters strategically.

Example scenarios:

- A food pantry operates Tuesday 10–noon, when most residents are at work. (Access Barrier)
- No programs address culturally appropriate food for the growing Somali community. (Service Gap)
- A SNAP enrollment office requires documentation that undocumented residents cannot provide. (Access Barrier)

Activity 4.3: The Decision Framework

Format: Guided reflection with scoring rubric | **Time:** 30 minutes

Take your identified gaps and evaluate each against four criteria:

- **Severity and urgency**: How many people are affected? Is this getting worse?
- **Current coverage**: Is anyone else working on this? How well?
- **Team fit**: Does your group have the skills, connections, or positioning to make a difference here?
- **Feasibility**: Can meaningful progress be made with realistic resources and timeline?

Each gap is scored on a simple low/medium/high scale across all four dimensions. The framework doesn't produce a single "right answer" but surfaces the tradeoffs and helps you articulate why you're choosing one direction over another.

Deliverable: Completed decision framework with written rationale for top-priority gap.

Activity 4.4: Branching Scenario: "Your Team's Crossroads"

Format: Interactive branching scenario (eLearning) or guided reflection with scoring rubric | **Time:** 30–40 minutes

This activity can be delivered as an interactive branching scenario in Storyline where you test out the results of the different options, or as a reflective assignment where you analyze the paths and document your reasoning.

Scenario Setup

You are part of a small team of community members in a mid-sized city. Over the past three sessions, you've mapped your community's hunger landscape and analyzed emerging changes. Your research has surfaced two compelling findings:

- The east side of town has become a food desert after a grocery store closure, and no current programs adequately fill the gap.
- Citywide, multiple food assistance programs exist but participation rates among eligible seniors are extremely low due to transportation and technology barriers.

Both are real needs, but your team has limited capacity. You need to choose a direction.

Path A: Address the Food Desert

Your team decides to focus on the east side service gap. The scenario guides you through a sequence of decisions:

1. A local church offers space for a weekly distribution. Do you partner with them, knowing your space is only available on Wednesdays? Or do you look for a secular venue that may cost money but offers more flexibility?
2. You discover another group was planning a community garden in the same area. Do you reach out to coordinate, potentially slowing your timeline? Or do you proceed independently to maintain momentum?
3. A city council member offers to help with funding but wants to announce the project at a press event next month, before you're ready. Do you accept the visibility and pressure, or decline and seek funding elsewhere?

Each choice leads to realistic consequences. No path is "wrong," but you see how decisions about partnerships, pacing, and politics shape what's possible.

Path B: Remove Barriers for Seniors

Your team decides to focus on the access barrier. The scenario guides you through:

1. You identify three existing meal programs with low senior participation. Do you approach all three about coordinating outreach, or focus on the one whose staff seems most receptive?
2. A team member suggests door-to-door visits in senior housing to understand barriers firsthand. Another argues this is too time-intensive and you should use existing survey data. Which approach do you take?
3. You learn the biggest barrier is that seniors don't trust programs that ask for personal information. Do you advocate for changing intake procedures (systemic but slow) or create a workaround like a no-questions-asked model (faster but limited)?

Path C: A Hybrid Approach

If you recognize that your team's findings suggest interconnection, for example, that seniors on the east side face both a service gap and access barriers, you can choose a hybrid path. This route is intentionally more complex, asking you to manage scope and avoid overcommitment while still addressing root causes.

eLearning note: *This scenario is designed for Storyline branching with 2–3 decision points per path and tailored feedback at each node. The final screen of each path provides a summary of*

what the team accomplished, what tradeoffs you made, and what questions remain, feeding directly into Module 5's Strategic Focus Brief.

Module 4 Assessment

Deliverable: Gap Analysis Summary (submitted to course journal)

You submit a 1–2-page summary that includes your completed gap analysis matrix, your decision framework scores and rationale, and a reflection on what the branching scenario revealed about your decision-making tendencies. This summary becomes the foundation for the Strategic Focus Brief in Module 5.

Module 5: From Findings to Focus

Session 5 | 2–3 hours

The final module brings everything together. You synthesize your capacity assessment, community map, emerging factors analysis, and gap identification into a single Strategic Focus Brief, the course's capstone deliverable.

Module Objectives:

- Synthesize findings from all prior modules into a coherent analysis of community need and team positioning.
- Write a Strategic Focus Brief that could be presented to potential partners, funders, or community stakeholders.
- Identify immediate next steps and the people or organizations needed to move forward.

Activities:

- **Brief Workshop:** Step-by-step guided drafting of the Strategic Focus Brief using a provided template with sections for community context, methodology, key findings, recommended focus area, and rationale.
- **Peer Review (cohort version):** Teams exchange briefs and provide structured feedback on clarity, evidence strength, and feasibility. Solo learners complete a self-review checklist.
- **Next Steps Roadmap:** Identify 3–5 concrete actions for the 30 days following course completion: who to contact, what to learn more about, and what first small step to take.
- **Module Deliverable:** Completed Strategic Focus Brief and 30-day action roadmap.

Design Notes for Reviewers

Assessment philosophy: This course uses authentic assessment throughout. There are no quizzes or knowledge checks divorced from application. Every deliverable is something the learner would use, such as a capacity profile, a resource map, an analysis, or a strategic document. The branching scenario in Module 4 assesses analytical thinking through simulated decision-making rather than recall.

Practitioner engagement: The course is built on the premise that community action teams should learn alongside people already doing the work.

Each session's live discussion includes space for a practitioner to react to the team's findings, challenge assumptions, and share practical knowledge. Teams may invite the same person throughout the course or bring in different practitioners across sessions to hear a range of perspectives. Either way, the practitioner's input shapes how you read your capability assessments, interpret your community maps, and evaluate potential areas of focus. Module 2's Informational Interview and Module 3's Voices from the Ground activities formalize this posture, but the regular Zoom conversations make it structural rather than episodic.

Scalability and accessibility: The course functions for a single motivated individual or a team of three to eight people working through it together. Group activities have solo alternatives. All activities include alternative formats. The cohort model adds peer learning and diverse perspective but is not required. Module 4 is designed for full interactive development.

Influences: The course content draws on Asset-Based Community Development principles and concepts common to systems thinking.